

The question you have to ask yourself is: Do you have the guts to publish? Fine. You feel you're not ready for prime time. But the itch just won't go away. You want to share your files. Tell the world you're a music maestro. And you want to do it now! This is what you do:

13.1 File Sharing

Online file sharing has a colourful and controversial history. Peer to peer (P2P) technologies have evolved over the years, in response to the various legal and social challenges of sharing copyrighted material. In the early days, we had the likes of Napster that used a centralised server to maintain searchable lists of files and directories of all users connected to the network. Individual users would search for the file they wanted to download and request it directly from a machine on the network. The subsequent legal battles finally shut down Napster in this form but it also paved the way for decentralised distribution through file sharing programs such as KaZaa, LimeWire, BearShare and others.

13.1.1 P2P

These days, file sharing happens via several different P2P networks (file sharing protocols); some of the most popular ones are Fast Track, eDonkey, Gnutella and BitTorrent. P2P file sharing relies on some method to pull different pieces of a file from various users (nodes) on the network. This splits the resource and bandwidth burden of sharing a file among several nodes, which (theoretically, at least) increases the efficiency of file sharing. While the principles are similar, the methods used by each network result in varying efficiencies, primarily depending on the type of connection you have. Thus, while BitTorrent may be most efficient for a broadband user, Gnutella or eDonkey may be more suited for those on dialup.

13.1.2 Legal Eagles—Is P2P legal?

This 64 million dollar question is still being fought over, with no